SAINT MICHAEL COLLEGE OF CARAGA

DUTY AND DISCIPLINE: AN EXPLORATORY STUDY OF POLICE OFFICERS PERCEPTIONS ON PHYSICAL FITNESS STANDARD AS PROVIDED BY THE PNP MEMORANDUM CIRCULAR 2020-029

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CHAPTER 1

THE PROBLEM AND ITS SCOPE

1.1 Background of the study

Physical fitness is crucial for police work, especially in a job that requires mental and physical strength. It has been recognized as the ability to perform daily tasks without undue fatigue while maintaining enough energy for leisure activities (Ward-Ritacco et al., 2022).

Law enforcement officers must be physically fit for health and job performance reasons. It is essential to carry out various responsibilities, such as handling paperwork, apprehending criminals, suppressing riots, and responding to emergencies (Koropanovski et al., 2020; Kukić et al., 2020; R. G. Lockie et al., 2020). In addition, future police officers (i.e., police students, cadets, or trainees) typically complete a physical training program to improve their fitness level before becoming sworn officers (Lockie et al., 2019). Similarly, some agencies require officers to undergo an annual fitness test upon starting work to maintain their physical fitness and health, enabling them to perform their jobs without undue fatigue (Schwartz, 2020).

International research indicates that police recruits receive specialized fitness training when they join the academy, but often discontinue these routines once they start working. Fitness is important when they begin, but police officers do not check it later (Vuković et al., 2020). Due to poor diet and limited resources, many officers lose their fitness and gain weight over time because they do not exercise well. Additionally, many police organizations also lack sufficient resources to maintain fitness programs, making it difficult for officers to always meet fitness standards (D. Blumberg et al., 2021; Čvorović et al., 2021). In the Philippines, the PNP launched a national fitness program called Pulisteniks to help officers maintain their job readiness through regular exercise (Aben, 2025). The police chief stated that being fit demonstrates readiness and discipline. They also suggest that a healthy figure with a smaller waist measurement can increase

people's trust in the police (Wagner et al., 2023). Pulisteniks is a great idea, but the program has some issues. For example, many people do not use it, and not many cops are participating. Individuals frequently engage in similar workouts, making them monotonous and unsustainable (Agoot Liza, 2025). One way to close this gap is to ensure that training plans match a person's fitness level. Police officers can do this initiative through physical and personal fitness evaluations.

A convenient way to perform the prescribed programs is to follow those written for a specific fitness level, which police can assess through a physical test battery or by well-established perceived physical fitness. However, physical fitness program is crucial for maintaining occupational health and physical performance once students become sworn officers, as police agencies often do not provide access to a strength and conditioning specialist or exercise facilities and equipment.

Negative changes in physical activity, physical fitness, and body composition shortly after cadets complete training may be partially attributed to whether cadets are competent or motivated to exercise independently (Orr et al., 2019). Lowering the gap between physical self-concept and measured physical fitness may indicate a learning process and a better understanding of officers fitness status, even though physical fitness objectively increases. This information may be necessary to sustain exercise programs in police occupations, as it also requires mental engagement. Regularly applied, well planned exercise programs could, in return, improve occupational health and performance.

However, it is unknown whether police officers' perceived and measured physical fitness differentiates health related and performance related indicators of physical fitness and whether perceived and measured physical fitness correlate. Therefore, the researcher aims to understand how police officers view the physical fitness requirements set by their department and governing

bodies. The second aim of the researcher is to gather insights to improve physical fitness policies, training, and support for officers.

The findings of this study will have real-world implications for the development and evaluation of police fitness programs. It would give police officers useful information about how well current training programs help them maintain their physical fitness. Knowing the difference between how fit someone thinks they are and how fit they are can help create more personalized, long-lasting fitness programs that give officers control over their health and performance. Keeping officers physically fit is essential for public safety, organizational readiness, and the organization's image and health. Furthermore, the outcome of this study will support the primary objective of improving police officers' physical fitness, lifestyle, morale, and overall well-being of police officers.

1.2 Theoretical Framework

In this study, the researchers need a clear framework to guide their research. The researchers have chosen a specific theory that will help them carry out this study.

THEORY OF PLANNED BEHAVIOR

The theory of planned behavior, introduced by Icek Ajzen in 1985, provides a structured model for predicting intentional behavior based on three primary constructs: attitude toward the behavior, subjective norms, and perceived behavioral control (PBC). This theory is particularly relevant for understanding why police officers choose to adhere or fail to adhere to fitness programs. Officers' attitudes toward fitness, shaped by beliefs about the benefits or drawbacks of physical activity, can significantly influence their intention to maintain a workout routine. For instance, if an officer views physical training as beneficial for health, career advancement, and

operational readiness, this positive attitude can motivate consistent engagement (Feng et al., 2023).

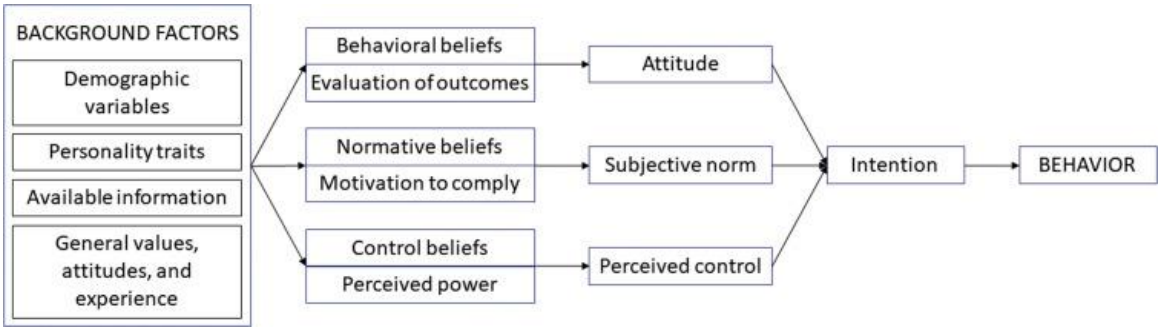


Figure 1: *Theory of Planned Behavior*

Figure 1 illustrates the framework of the Theory of Planned Behavior, which assumes that individuals have deliberate control over their behavior. The harder individuals try to perform a behavior, the more likely they are to succeed. Individuals are more likely to perform a behavior if they have a favorable attitude (perception of the consequences of the behavior) and a subjective norm (perception of others' approval) about the behavior, and have a high degree of perceived control (perception of the difficulty in performing the behavior). Media interventions that work on changing attitudes and subjective norms to be more favorable and to increase perception of control could be effective in reducing stigma.

In the Philippine context, Tupas (2025) notes that mandates such as regular Physical Fitness Tests (PFTs), BMI monitoring, and APEs reflect institutional attempts to influence subjective norms and perceived control by creating structure and consequences. However, the mere presence of these policies does not guarantee compliance—officers must believe they can perform the behaviors and value the outcomes that result from them. Furthermore, fitness interventions like Pulisteniks, as described by Aben (2025), act as facilitators for behavior change by improving perceived control through accessible training and support systems.

Subjective norms, or the perceived social pressure to perform or not perform a behavior, also play a crucial role in a collective and hierarchical structure, such as the police force. Suppose colleagues and superiors place a high value on physical fitness, as demonstrated by institutional policies such as annual physical fitness tests and the potential removal from service for non-compliance (Cabuenas, 2018). In that case, officers may feel socially compelled to participate in these programs. These norms shape officers' intentions by making physical fitness a professional expectation and social responsibility.

Recent studies apply TPB to explain health-related behavior in high-stakes professions like law enforcement. Lu et al. (2020) observed that, despite the recognized significance of physical fitness in law enforcement, numerous officers disregard structured exercise programs following academy training. This change can be attributed to a decline in behavioral intention, which is influenced by reduced support or perceived barriers, such as time constraints or shift schedules.

In line with TPB's attitudinal component, officers' beliefs about the benefits of fitness (e.g., improved performance, reduced injury risk, career advancement) play a critical role in determining their willingness to maintain physical health (Lentz et al., 2019; Murphy, 2021). Officers who associate fitness with improved public service outcomes are more likely to adhere to wellness programs. Perceived behavioral control, akin to self-efficacy, also heavily impacts adherence to physical fitness programs. Officers who feel they lack the time, facilities, or support to exercise may choose not to engage, even if they value fitness (Wagner et al., 2023). Despite favorable attitudes, factors such as lack of funding, irregular work shifts, and low motivation create barriers that can suppress intention.

Furthermore, TPB provides a comprehensive framework for understanding the motivational factors that influence physical fitness behavior among police personnel. TPB focuses

on intentions driven by attitudes, norms, and perceived behavioral control. This theory explains why some officers actively maintain fitness while others struggle despite institutional mandates. By applying this model, the study can better assess how fitness perceptions and individual motivation interact to influence performance effectiveness in the Philippine National Police and similar law enforcement agencies.

1.3 Review of Related Literature

This chapter presents the related literature to provide a frame of reference for this study, focusing on the lived experiences of PNP personnel. The study examines the demographics of PNP Personnel as independent variables and the perceptions of police officers on physical fitness standards in terms of: Physical Conditioning, Physical Fitness Test, Annual Physical Examination, and Body Mass Index as dependent variables. It aims to provide insights, understanding, and improvement for future researchers.

Related Literatures

Police officers must be physically fit; fitness tests usually check their strength, endurance, and heart health. However, police work is challenging, so being in good shape is important. However, studies show that police officers often become less physically fit as they age, which means they may lose some strength, energy, and endurance (Sandvik et al., 2020).

Lockie et al. (2020) and Rodas et al. (2021) examined how police officers stay in shape, what they think about the fitness needed for their work, and whether or not health programs work well in police duties. Police officers must be fit to do their jobs well and stay safe. However, Blumberg et al. (2019) argued that police officers typically give up fitness assessments after completing their academy training, despite the continuous challenges of their roles. In addition, studies have shown that police officers often experience a decline in fitness levels over time,

stated that being fit helps officers do their jobs well and improves their quality of life (Lentz et al., 2019b; Marins et al., 2019). Being physically fit is very important for police officers and trainees because it helps them do their jobs well and stay healthy (Orr et al., 2019). According to Neumann et al. (2022), being fit means having the strength and energy to do everyday things, handle stress, and stay active.

Police officers must be fit to look good, have the energy to do their jobs, and stay safe when things get tough (Murphy et al., 2024). A similar study of (Sandvik et al., 2022) asserts that an unfit officer may inflict self-harm or utilize excessive force under challenging circumstances. Kuhns et al. (2015) contend that law enforcement personnel in the United States encounter numerous health issues, including stress, fatigue, poor nutrition, and a range of physical and mental health conditions and disorders, which is why police officers need wellness programs so much.

In the Philippines, Lt. Gen. Archie Gamboa of the police started a campaign to fight obesity among officers. He even suggested a yogurt diet to one officer. Police officers who are overweight would not be allowed to train or promoted until they met the BMI (body mass index) requirement. At that time, Gamboa said that almost half of the 190,000 police officers were overweight or obese, and he also demonstrated the importance of police officers being physically fit. Only about 102,600 officers (54%) had a healthy weight, while 17,100 (9%) were considered obese (Tupas Emmanuel, 2025).

Republic Act No. 8551 declares that no one is eligible to join the Philippine National Police unless they pass specific tests, such as mental health, drug, and fitness tests. Police officers or approved hospitals can do this test to ensure new officers can do their jobs (Caliwan, 2020). The police think officers in good shape can do their duties better. RA No. 6975, amended by RA No.

8551, says that people who want to be police officers must weigh within 5 kilograms of their standard height, age, and sex. In addition, when officers join, they must meet these fitness standards and keep them up throughout their careers. If they do not, they could lose their job (Sapii, 2023). Furthermore, this study examines physical conditioning, physical fitness tests, annual physical examinations, and BMI, as outlined in PNP rules.

Aben (2025) reports that the police are stricter about fitness, especially under Chief Nicolas Torre III. If an officer fails the Physical Fitness Test (PFT) twice, they cannot get promoted or take any more training. The goal is to ensure preparedness for all officers for their jobs in the real world. The law says that officers must take the PFT every year, keep their BMI healthy, and stay within five pounds of their ideal body weight (John et al., 2020). However, being overweight and not getting enough exercise are common problems for police. Police chiefs agree that staying in shape is essential for performing their jobs effectively, maintaining safety, and earning public trust.

Wagner et al. (2023) found that unfit officers are more likely to experience difficulties in de-escalation, sustain injuries, and lose trust. However, problems often slow things down, like insufficient money, inconsistent hours, insufficient space, and low motivation. These findings indicate that although standards and expectations regarding physical fitness are commonly recognized at leadership levels, significant implementation challenges undermine their reliability. This means that police who think fitness standards are important also think organizations should help them follow them by giving them the necessary tools and resources (Melton et al., 2023).

Many police officers are overweight because they do not get enough exercise. All police leaders agree that being in good shape is important for doing the job well, staying safe, and earning the trust of the people they serve (Strauss et al., 2021). In this study, the independent

variables identified were age, gender, weight, and rank or position; these demographics explain differences among police officers. In addition, the dependent variables of this study are the physical conditioning, physical fitness test, annual physical examination, and body mass index.

Age

The Philippine National Police (PNP) recognizes that staying fit is crucial for performing its duties effectively and maintaining safety. As people age, their bodies may not be as robust as they once were. That is why the PNP has created special fitness rules and programs for people of all ages.

Research shows that police officers, including those in the Philippines, lose some fitness as they age. These findings mean that their heart and lung strength, muscle power, and body shape can change, making demanding physical tasks more difficult and increasing health risks (Aben, 2025). According to a study by Agoot Liza (2025), the PNP needs police officers of all ages to stay healthy by taking fitness tests and participating in fitness programs like Pulisteniks. In addition, the PNP also has rules about how much weight police officers can lift and how well they can do things based on age, to monitor the officers' health as they get older, and help them get better.

R. Orr et al. (2021) argued that as police officers get older, their fitness in critical areas for police work tends to get worse unlike younger officers that are task for duties. Because of this, many police departments have exceptional fitness standards and wellness programs tailored to people of different ages or jobs.

Frick et al. (2024) suggest that age affects the physical fitness of police officers. Age is crucial when administering fitness tests and establishing guidelines for hiring, retaining, and managing police officers. Their review examined fitness standards and policy reports from

different places to find what they have in common and what is missing. Research from the Buffalo Police Department found that police officers live, on average, 22 years less than the general population. Between 1997 and 2018, 82% of police officers in the U.S. who died from circulatory problems died from heart attacks. These heart attacks often happened around age 46 (Violanti et al., 2021).

Physical fitness usually decreases with age. Muscle strength and power also decline, making it more challenging for older officers to perform essential tasks such as chasing suspects, rescuing people, or protecting themselves. Studies show that while officers may start their careers stronger than average persons, their strength declines faster as they age. Although police departments employ officers of various ages, the physical demands typically remain consistent as officers age (Anderson et al., 2019).

Teixeira et al. (2019) identified which physical fitness skills are most important for police officers in four age groups: 20–29, 30–39, 40–49, and over 49 years old. Additionally, Araujo et al. (2021) describe the effect of age on the somatic and physical fitness of a Special Police Unit (SPU) and try to learn about things that change as you age. Lockie et al. (2022) conducted a similar study, revealing that officers typically show above-average strength compared to the general population across different age groups. However, strength and power decrease as people age, especially after 40. This pattern is like other operational groups and helps with ongoing strength and power training throughout careers.

Gender

The Philippine National Police (PNP) ensures that police officers are ready for duty by making them participate in physical fitness assessments (PFA) regularly (Buchanan, 2025). In addition, the PNP's Human Resource and Doctrine Development (HRDD) rules say that men and

women must meet different fitness standards and recognize physical differences (PNP Memorandum Circular No. 2020-034). Some critics, on the other hand, say that these standards could make gender inequality worse without meaning to. They argue that the rules are insufficient to help female officers deal with the social and institutional problems they face during training and while on the job (Pumarada, 2023).

Research shows apparent differences in physical fitness between male and female police officers. Most of the time, men do better on fitness tests than women (Bloodgood et al., 2021). Men can do more push-ups and run faster than women because they have more muscle and better aerobic capacity. Women officers tend to have more body fat and lower scores on tests of strength and endurance, which affects their overall fitness (Dawes et al., 2023). However, research also shows that female officers have some good points. Compared to male officers, women are less likely to use much force and are more careful about who they search or arrest (Morabito et al., 2018).

In addition, Biswas et al. (2021) found that female police officers have unique problems with their work schedules and fitness requirements, which are often made difficult by society's roles and expectations. However, training programs for female officers have been shown to help them get in better shape. These programs involve improving body composition, strength, and endurance.

Research indicates that a higher body fat percentage in both men and women police officers correlates with decreased performance in critical police duties. Studies show how important it is to have fitness standards and training, and how men and women are different and give them the help they need (Carrilho et al., 2023). Additionally, some places have fitness standards that are easier for women to meet. These are known as sex-normed standards. Some

people disagree with this practice, and some think that everyone should have the same fitness standards and that it improves police preparedness, no matter what gender they are (Rev et al., 2024).

Gender impacts the physical fitness of Philippine police officers by affecting their levels of fitness, the problems they have to deal with, and how practical their training is. Officers can perform their jobs more effectively and feel better overall by establishing fitness and wellness programs, considering these gender differences. To completely understand these problems within the Philippines' distinct organizational and cultural framework (Henze et al., 2024). There are differences in the fitness level of male and female police officers. Men usually do better on tests of strength and endurance. However, female officers can boost their fitness with specialized training. Furthermore, the debate continues about whether police fitness standards should be different for men and women or the same for everyone, as both approaches attempt to achieve equality and effectiveness in law enforcement (Violanti et al., 2021).

Weight

According to Section 30, paragraph (i) of RA 6975, police officers in the Philippines cannot exceed more than five kilograms over or under the standard weight for their age, height, and sex. It demonstrates that police officers really care about their health and weight. Similarly, the Philippine National Police (PNP) strictly follows the rule that officers must stay within 5 kilograms of the standard set by RA 6975 (the Department of the Interior and Local Government Act of 1990) (Tupas, 2025). Police officers take fitness tests as part of their overall fitness tests; they must meet specific weight and body composition standards. These standards are meant to ensure that police officers maintain a healthy weight that is good for their physical fitness needs (Mc Loughlin, 2019).

By emphasizing a comprehensive approach to physical preparedness, these requirements maintain the capacity of the police force. These programs are often designed to meet officers' needs based on age, gender, and role to improve their health and job performance (R. Orr et al., 2025). In addition, every three months, officers will undergo BMI monitoring; if police officers fail to reach the BMI requirement, they will be required to lose weight. Every year, there are fitness tests. However, they could lose their job if they fail these tests twice (Sigales, 2025). To help with this, the Philippine National Police started a required fitness program called the Pulisteniks. This program aims to help police officers lose weight and become more physically fit (Mendoza, 2021). Most of the time, it could take anywhere from a few months to a year to reach fitness and weight goals.

The Philippine National Police also checks factors such as bone structure when enforcing weight standards to ensure no one will be mistreated. This detailed plan clarifies how important it is for police to monitor their weight regularly. It aims to improve professionalism, health, and preparedness for duty in the Philippines (Aben, 2025). On the other hand, keeping weight within the set limits for police job performance, stamina, and professional image is important. It may be harder for police officers who are overweight to do their jobs effectively because they have to be physically fit.

The PNP encourages police officers to manage their weight by following strict fitness programs and having regular health checks (Casilao, 2021). This program shows a strong effort to set weight and fitness standards to help police officers stay ready for their jobs. These practices support keeping fit and managing weight as important parts of being a good police officer and staying healthy. Police fitness rules include weight as a key part, ensuring officers meet high health and fitness standards to handle the physical demands of their work.

Rank

Studies show that police officers must be physically fit to do their jobs well. New police officers must pass strict fitness tests, which check if they can handle different tasks and respond to emergencies (John et al., 2019). Even though higher-ranking officers often have less stress, it is still important to stay fit so they are ready to act when needed (Feng et al., 2023).

Researchers found that they could track how police officers performed on fitness tests each year by using percentile ranks (Lockie et al., 2022). In addition, rank in police forces typically reflects hierarchy, responsibility, and length of service. As officers move from entry-level positions (e.g., Patrolman) to higher ranks (e.g., Sergeant, Lieutenant, Captain), their duties often shift from fieldwork to administrative or supervisory roles. Higher-ranking officers frequently had less physically demanding roles, possibly contributing to lower physical activity levels (Marins et al., 2019).

These role changes can impact physical activity levels and physical fitness. Across all ranks, there tends to be a consensus that fitness is crucial for overall health and that agencies support officer fitness through resources or time allowances for exercise during shifts (Kukić et al., 2019). However, the level of advocacy for strict or mandatory fitness testing varies, often influenced by personal fitness levels, changes in job roles, and experiences over time.

Police officers involved in physically demanding duties, such as patrol and tactical units, tend to maintain a higher level of physical fitness than administrative employees. However, changes in roles can change how much people work out, which can change how fit they are (R. Orr et al., 2025). Also, rank affects the physical fitness standards in policing, ensuring that the job's physical demands match each officer's skills. Agencies also change their fitness rules to fit their needs (Feng et al., 2023).

Previous research indicates that physical fitness standards for police officers are based upon their roles, with greater performance expectations for those in subordinate positions than those in higher-ranking positions. Maintaining fitness throughout a career is essential, especially in the face of age-related declines, to ensure officers can meet the physical demands of law enforcement and maintain job effectiveness (Massuça et al., 2022). Generally, higher-ranking officers view physical fitness differently than officers of a lower rank. According to Strack et al. (2024) study, officers in lower ranks often perceive physical fitness standards as a critical job requirement, whereas higher-rank officers sometimes perceive physical fitness standards as less critical, prioritizing other aspects of their job, such as administrative duties.

Police officers in lower ranks are more likely to emphasize the importance of physical fitness, while higher-rank officers may perceive physical fitness as less central to their role as police officers.

Physical Conditioning

The Philippine National Police (PNP) Memorandum Circular No. 2020-029, titled the "Revised PNP Comprehensive Health and Physical Fitness Program," emphasizes the importance of physical conditioning for police officers to maintain their physical fitness. This program includes planned exercises that help improve heart and lung health, muscle strength, and flexibility (Pumarada, 2023).

Maintaining good physical health is crucial for police officers to perform their duties effectively. Studies show that police work requires strong muscles, endurance, and agility, as the job can be physically demanding (Zulfiqar et al., 2021). On the other hand, physical conditioning programs focus on balance exercises and other activities to prepare police officers for situations where they may need to use force (Oluwafemi et al., 2023).

Physical conditioning encompasses health education, and regular checks are part of it to ensure officers meet the physical standards needed for their jobs. The memorandum says that following the rules for physical fitness is linked to career progression, including promotion eligibility, underscoring the importance PNP places on the physical readiness of its officers (Gubalani, 2020). Physical conditioning among police officers' physical fitness standards is critical to maintaining job performance, preventing injury risks, and overall health quality (Massuça et al., 2022).

As stated in the PNP Memorandum Circular (2020), all PNP personnel must engage in regular physical conditioning as part of the Comprehensive Health and Physical Fitness program. They shall submit their respective individual programs to the Chief Admin of their respective office.

All offices/units shall also initiate a physical conditioning and wellness program and submit the same to the Directorate for Human Resources and Doctrine Development or equivalent offices in the Police Regional Office or National Support Unit. The circular says that police officers need to be dedicated to physical fitness to stay healthy, ready, and effective. The study says that MC 2020-029, which combines career development, fitness testing, weight control, and health into one plan, is vital for the Philippine police to maintain their physical fitness standards (Pumarada, 2023).

Furthermore, physical conditioning among police officers involves multifaceted fitness assessments and training protocols targeting strength, endurance, power, and cardiovascular health to enhance job performance, reduce injuries, and maintain operational readiness throughout their careers (Murphy et al., 2021).

Physical Fitness Test

The PNP Memorandum Circular No. 2020-029 includes a physical fitness program, such as the Physical Fitness Test (PFT), to help police officers stay fit. This test checks how well their hearts and lungs work, how strong their muscles are, and how flexible they are. The test includes push-ups, sit-ups, a timed run, and other simple exercises. Police officers take this test regularly to ensure they are strong and healthy enough for their tough jobs (Pumarada, 2023).

In addition, physical fitness tests for police officers are made to check many important skills needed for their job, like how well their heart and lungs work, how strong and fast they are, and how well they can move quickly. Standard tests include a 2.4 km (1.5-mile) run, push-ups, sit-ups, grip strength tests, and obstacle courses similar to real police work (Lockie et al., 2021). Police have created fitness tests that focus on the kinds of tasks they actually do on the job. Studies show that push-ups and the 2.4 km run are the most common tests and are closely linked to finishing police training and doing well at work (Feng et al., 2023).

The PNP Memorandum Circular (2020) requires officers to achieve the minimum required scores in these tests to demonstrate their physical capability. The PFT is integrated with quarterly weight monitoring to ensure officers keep their body weight within prescribed limits (not more than 5 kg above or below the standard weight for height and age), linking physical conditioning to overall fitness standards. However, failure to meet the fitness requirements consecutively may result in administrative sanctions, including reassignment or separation from the service.

Recent studies further support the predictive value of fitness tests for job-specific tasks, suggesting that fitness assessments should be comprehensive and tailored to capture essential physical skills for police duties. Programs encouraging continuous conditioning and periodic re-

testing contribute to sustained officer health and effective performance (Hall, 2022; Lockie et al., 2023; R. M. Orr et al., 2020)

Pumarada (2023) looked at how PNP MC 2020-029 is used in the Philippines and found that the Physical Fitness Test (PFT) helps police officers become more aware of their fitness and encourages them to live healthier lives. The rule also supports ongoing health education, fitness programs, and the PFT to help officers stay physically and mentally healthy. This complete approach ensures that officers meet fitness standards and keep them up through regular exercise and healthy habits, helping the Philippine National Police do their job well.

Furthermore, physical fitness tests are used to select recruits and monitor fitness throughout an officer's career, supporting injury prevention and operational readiness. Agencies often base their fitness standards on scientifically validated programs, which recommend comprehensive assessment across aerobic capacity, anaerobic power, muscular strength, endurance, flexibility, and body composition (Murphy et al., 2022; Tavares et al., 2025).

Annual Physical Examination

The Annual Physical Examination is an important part of keeping police officers healthy. A regular check-up helps find and treat health problems early, before they become serious. This exam includes a physical check-up, an Electrocardiogram (ECG), a chest X-ray, and lab tests like a complete blood count, urinalysis, blood sugar test, kidney and liver function tests, cholesterol check, and other important tests (Pumarada, 2023).

In addition, the Annual Physical Examination (APE) is a requirement for all PNP officers who are 40 years old and above, and it is scheduled according to their birth month. This exam is part of a bigger plan to keep police officers physically and mentally healthy so they can handle the demands of their job. The exam results help find health problems, and officers who need help are

sent for more tests or treatment. These results can affect whether they are fit for duty and their chances for promotion. However, officers who do not meet the health standards may face actions like being removed from the force or being medically retired, as stated in the PNP's rules about health and job status (Gubalani, 2020).

Annual physical examinations and fitness tests among police officers are crucial for monitoring health, fitness, and operational readiness throughout officers' careers. Studies emphasize that regular physical fitness assessments, including aerobic capacity, muscular endurance, strength, and body composition, are valuable tools for predicting job performance and risk of injuries (Oluwafemi Emmanuel et al., 2023b). Despite the recognized importance of annual exams, some countries and agencies lack standardized fitness monitoring beyond recruitment, which can lead to health problems. The literature recommends implementing mandatory annual or biannual fitness tests, focusing on aerobic fitness due to the high cardiovascular risk among police officers.

Furthermore, as stated in the PNP Memorandum Circular (2020), the Health Service/Regional Health Service shall conduct and supervise the Annual Physical Examination at their respective PNP health facilities. Not all laboratory procedures are available at all PNP health facilities; the PNP medical officer shall refer them to any Department of Health (DOH) accredited laboratories. In summary, annual physical examinations and fitness assessments are vital in policing to support sustained physical fitness, prevent injuries, and reduce health-related costs. They encourage continuous fitness management over an officer's career, improving individual well-being and organizational effectiveness (Hall, 2022).

Body Mass Index

All PNP officers, regardless of age, gender, or rank, must have their Body Mass Index (BMI) checked and recorded during the first week of every month. Their Admin Officers will measure and keep track of the results and each officer's physical health profile in a special form and database (PNP Memorandum Circular, 2020). Research among law enforcement officers has consistently reported that body mass increases with years of service (Gonzalez et al., 2025). Prioritizing once BMI is very crucial in the job performance of police officers, because their job is physically demanding (Sergi et al., 2023).

In the Philippine National Police (PNP), Body Mass Index (BMI) is an important part of the fitness rules for police officers. Every month, all PNP personnel must have their BMI checked to make sure their weight is healthy for their height. The rules set acceptable BMI ranges based on age and gender. Officers are grouped as underweight, normal weight, overweight, or obese. For most police officers, a healthy BMI is between 18.5 and 27.0, but this range can change depending on age (Casilao, 2021). In addition, Liza Agoot (2025) study highlights the PNP MC 2020-029 age specific BMI classifications for personnel, with normal ranges starting at 18.5-24.9 for those 29 years old, extending to 18.5-25.0 for ages 30-34, 18.5-25.5 for 35-39, 18.5-26.0 for 40-44, 18.5-26.5 for 45-50, and 18.5-27.0 for 51 years old. Overweight categories follow as 25.1-29.9 for 29 and 30-34, 25.6-29.9 for 35-39, 26.1-29.9 for 40-44, 26.6-29.9 for 45-50, and 27.4-29.9 for 51, while obesity levels (Obese I: 30.0-34.9, Obese II: 35.0-39.9, Obese III: 40) apply across all ages.

However, the Philippine National Police (PNP) requires strict BMI monitoring as part of its policing fitness standards. Officers who exceed the standard BMI are placed under wellness programs that involve nutrition, individualized physical conditioning, and regular monitoring, with consequences if fitness standards are not met within given timeframes. BMI also informs eligibility for promotion and special assignments (Agoot Liza, 2025).

Personnel with a BMI exceeding the standard are subject to fitness programs designed to promote weight reduction and overall improved fitness to meet operational requirements. Muscular or athletic physiques that may exceed BMI norms but fit waist circumference standards are also considered, avoiding unfair penalization (Gonzalez et al., 2025). However, during the COVID-19 pandemic, PNP Chief Guillermo Eleazar temporarily suspended the use of body mass index as a requirement for promotion (Mendoza, 2021).

Officers who go over the BMI limit must join fitness programs to help them lose weight and improve their overall health to meet their job's needs. However, if an officer is very muscular or has an athletic build and only exceeds the BMI because of this, they will not be penalized as long as their waist size is within the healthy range (Agoot Liza, 2025).

The Body Mass Index (BMI) is commonly used as a key standard in assessing the physical fitness and overall health of police officers. Research shows that BMI measured in law enforcement populations effectively screens for overweight and obesity, conditions known to decrease physical performance and increase injury risk. Higher BMI among police officers is consistently associated with poorer outcomes on fitness tests, including push-ups, sit-ups, aerobic capacity, and vertical jump performance (Gonzalez et al., 2025) .

Furthermore, BMI is a critical component of physical fitness standards for police officers in the Philippines. It helps identify officers at risk of fitness decline and supports targeted interventions to maintain fitness, reduce injury, and ensure operational readiness (Dominski et al., 2018).

1.4 Schematic Diagram

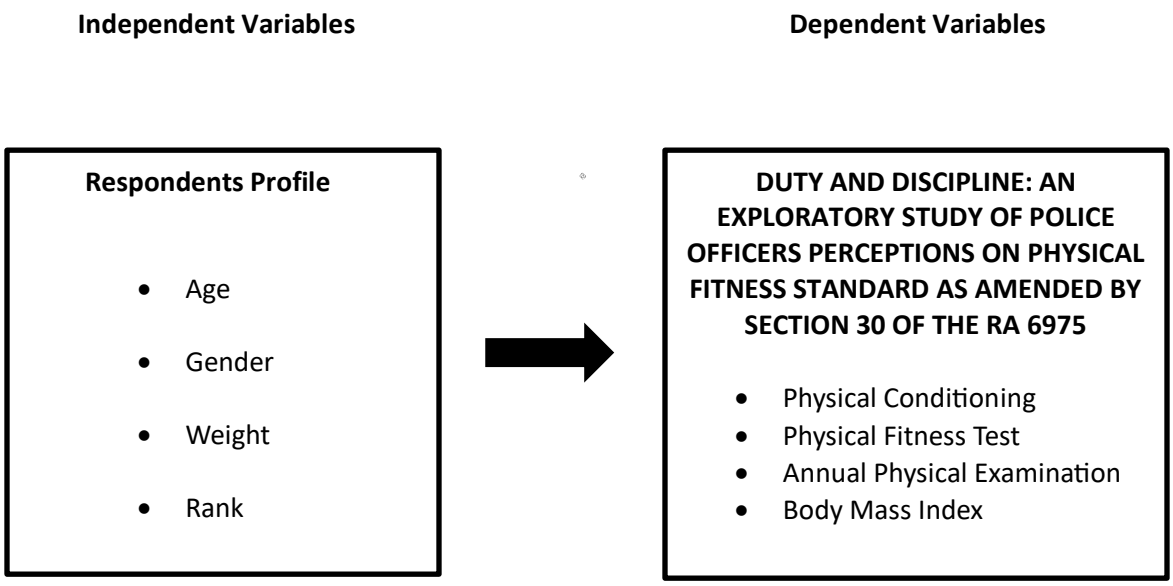


Figure 2. The Schematic Diagram shows the relationship between the dependent and independent variables of the study.

1.5 Statement of the Problem/ Objectives of the Study

This quantitative study aims to determine the relationship between selected demographic and service-related factors and the physical health status of the respondents. Specifically, it seeks to assess how the independent variables influence the dependent variables.

This study aims to answer the following questions:

1. What are the respondents' demographic and service-related profiles in terms of:

    1.1. age;

    1.2 gender;

    1.3 weight;

    1.4 rank?

2. What is the level of the respondents' perception of the physical fitness standard in terms of:

    2.1 Physical Conditioning;

    2.2 Physical Fitness Test Results;

    2.3 Annual Physical Examination;

    2.4 Body Mass Index (BMI)?

3. Is there a significant relationship between the respondents' profiles and the perception of physical fitness standards?

1.6 Hypothesis

The following hypothesis will guide the study.

H1. There is no significant relationship between the respondents' perception on physical fitness standard when grouped according to their profile.

1.7 Scope and Limitations

This study will be conduct among Philippine National Police (PNP) personnel assigned to Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen Municipal Police Station. The respondents consisted of 62 active PNP personnel, selected based on availability and willingness to participate in the study. The research focused on determining the relationship between selected demographic and service-related variables, namely age, gender, weight, and rank, and the respondents' perceptions of physical fitness standards.

The scope of the study is limited to the respondents' perceptions of physical fitness standards in terms of physical conditioning, physical fitness test, annual physical examination, and body mass index (BMI), as implemented by the Philippine National Police under existing policies and memorandum circulars. A quantitative research design will be utilize, and data will be gather through a structured survey questionnaire to assess the respondents' level of perception regarding these fitness standards.

This study is limited in that it will not include direct measurement or actual administration of physical fitness tests, medical examinations, or BMI assessments. Instead, it relied on self-reported data, which may be influenced by personal judgment, honesty of responses, and the respondents' understanding of the fitness standards. Additionally, factors such as motivation, workload, health conditions, and access to fitness resources were not explored in depth and were beyond the scope of this study.

Moreover, the findings are limited to the selected locale and number of respondents and may not be generalized to all PNP personnel nationwide or to other law enforcement agencies. Differences in assignment, operational demands, leadership support, and availability of fitness facilities may affect perceptions across other units.

Despite these limitations, the study provides meaningful insights into how PNP personnel perceive existing physical fitness standards and how these perceptions vary according to demographic and service-related factors. The results may serve as a basis for improving physical fitness policies, training programs, and support mechanisms within the Philippine National Police.

1.8 Definition of Terms

To better understand or enhance comprehension, the following terms in this research are operationally used:

Age. Refers to the number of years a police officer has lived, which may influence their physical fitness, endurance, and overall health. It is a variable considered when setting fitness benchmarks and tailoring training programs.

Annual Physical Examination. A comprehensive health assessment is conducted once a year to evaluate an individual's overall physical condition. In the context of this study, it refers to the routine medical check-up required of police officers in the Philippines to ensure they are physically and medically fit to perform their duties.

BMI. A numerical value that estimates a police officer's body fat based on their weight and height, to better understand their weight status, identify possible health risks, and take steps toward a healthier lifestyle.

Gender. Describes the biological and physiological characteristics typically associated with being male or female. In the context of this study, it is used to examine how physical fitness standards and performance outcomes vary between male and female police officers.

Occupational Readiness. Describes the state of being physically and mentally prepared to perform the duties and responsibilities associated with police work safely and effectively.

Perception. The method through which people make sense of and interpret sensory information or experiences. In this study, perception pertains to how police officers perceive, interpret, and assess the significance, implementation, and effectiveness of physical fitness standards and the yearly check-up.

Physical Fitness. Refers to the ability of an individual to perform daily tasks and occupational duties effectively without undue fatigue, and with sufficient energy for leisure activities. In the context of law enforcement, it includes both health-related and performance-related components necessary for executing physically demanding police duties such as pursuit, restraint, and emergency response.

Physical Fitness Perception. A person's self-assessment of their physical ability and appearance influences motivation to exercise and maintain physical fitness. In police settings, a strong physical self-concept supports sustained engagement in fitness activities.

Physical Fitness Standard. A set of criteria or benchmarks established by the Philippine National Police (PNP) or related agencies that measure the physical readiness and capability of police officers to perform their duties. These standards typically include fitness tests such as running, push-ups, sit-ups, and other performance-based assessments.

Physical Fitness Test (PFT). A standardized assessment conducted to measure an officer's physical capabilities, typically including exercises such as push-ups, sit-ups, timed runs, and other activities that evaluate strength, endurance, and agility.

Police Officer. A uniformed member of the Philippine National Police (PNP) tasked with enforcing the law, maintaining peace and order, and ensuring public safety. The term includes both male and female officers regardless of rank or assignment.

Pulisteniks. A fitness campaign introduced by the Philippine National Police (PNP) combining "pulis" (police) and "calisthenics." It aims to improve the health and physical condition of police officers through regular exercise, with overweight officers required to participate to meet BMI and performance standards.

CHAPTER 2

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

This chapter goes into more detail about the steps taken to reach the study's goal. Additionally, it involves the methodology employed as a framework for the study, the requirements for selecting the research sample from the population, the research materials utilized, and the methods used for analyzing the collected data. The strengths and weaknesses of the research methodology were also looked at in great detail, and the ethical considerations of the research were thoroughly discussed.

2.1 Research Design

This study will employ a descriptive-correlational research design to carefully describe perceptions and correlate them with actual fitness measures, making it a strong model for research on police officers' fitness perceptions. The descriptive part will be used to describe and summarize police officers' perceptions of physical fitness standards, and to quantify how police officers perceive the importance, fairness, and impact of the current physical fitness standards (e.g., BMI requirements, physical fitness tests, and career implications). The correlational part will explore the relationships between police officers' perceptions and demographic or occupational factors (e.g., age, gender, rank, BMI, and physical fitness performance) (Sapii, 2023). This design will enable researchers to explore police officers' perceptions of physical fitness standards and understand how these perceptions relate to professional factors. It will help stakeholders understand current attitudes and identify actionable patterns without requiring experimental control or manipulation.

2.2 Research Materials and Methods

A quantitative method will be employ to describe police officers' perceptions of physical fitness standards, using structured survey questions. A quantitative methodology involves measuring variables using a numerical system, analyzing these measurements using various statistical models, and reporting relationships and associations among the studied variables (Bhandari Pritha, 2020).

The primary tool for data collection will be a self-administered, structured questionnaire using a five-point Likert scale. This questionnaire is specifically designed to collect data on how police officers perceive physical fitness standards. The questionnaire consists of a Likert scale developed by McLeod (2023), which includes items to measure how police officers perceive their physical fitness based on their profile. This tool can be used to gather data from active-duty police officers. The questionnaire will be construct into four sections: Perceptions on physical conditioning, physical fitness test, annual physical examination, and body mass index, with options ranging from 1 (Strongly Disagree) to 5 (Strongly Agree).

Part 1 of the instrument focuses on basic demographic and service information among police officers, including age, gender, rank, years of service, and current assignment.

Part 2 of the instrument focuses on evaluating perceptions of Physical Conditioning, Physical Fitness Tests, Annual Physical Examinations, and Body Mass Index for police officers to assess respondents' levels of perception of job performance.

2.3 Research Environment, Population and Sample

This study will be conduct in the municipal police stations of Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen (BueNasCar) in the province of Agusan del Norte, chosen to represent a cross-section of local police officer units under the jurisdiction of the Philippine National Police (PNP). These police stations operate in diverse environments and are tasked to maintain public safety, peace, and

order in their respective areas. The selected municipal police stations were identified based on population size and approval from the municipal police station head.

The population of this research will consist of active-duty officers assigned to these municipal stations, regardless of rank or specialization, who have undergone or are familiar with the agency's physical standard fitness standards. This population was deemed appropriate for the study as it provides insights from officers through the implementation and evaluation of physical fitness requirements. We employed a purposive sampling technique for our respondents to select 20 from Buenavista, 20 from Nasipit, and 22 from Carmen.

Table 1 presents the selected municipal police stations and their respective population data to describe the research environment further.

Table 1. Respondents of the Study

LOCATION	Population	
	F	%
Buenavista	20	32.3
Nasipit	20	32.3
Carmen	22	35.5
Total	**62**	**100.0**

2.4 Research Data and Analysis Plan

To determine the number of police officers at the municipal police stations in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, Agusan del Norte, the researchers will ask the chief of police and the officer-in-charge of the station for permission. To obtain permission to conduct the study and collect data from police officers, the researchers will submit a letter to be deliver to the municipal police stations. After receiving the respondents' list, the researchers will carefully organize the data collection procedure, ensuring that the research's rights, security, and advantages are explained to the participants.

Then, the researchers will provide the respondents with an informed consent form, which includes a detailed explanation of the study's purpose and procedures. PNP personnel will be allowed to review and sign the consent form, indicating their understanding and voluntary agreement to participate in the study.

Once the informed consent is signed, the researchers will collect it and distribute the questionnaire to the respondents. The questionnaire will be provided through personal consultations to accommodate each respondent's preferences. Following the distribution phase, the researchers will collect all the questionnaires and analyze, check, tally, and interpret the results using the identified statistical tool.

All data will then be organized and encoded for statistical analysis. After analysis, a summary of the findings will be provided to the PNP personnel to promote transparency.

The data will be analyzed using appropriate statistical methods:

Frequency and percentage distribution. It will answer SOP 1, the profile of the respondents in terms of age, gender, weight, and rank.

Mean. It will help to determine the overall level of perceptions on SOP 2 based on Likert-scale ratings.

Pearson Correlation. It will assess the relationship between the demographic profile of respondents and the dependent variables (Physical Conditioning, Physical Fitness Test, Annual Physical Examination, and Body Mass Index) on the perception of physical fitness standards.

2.5 Research Ethical Standards

Before commencing data gathering, the researchers obtained ethics clearance from the Institutional Research Ethics Committee and secured written permission from the Officer-in-Charge and the Chief of Police. All participants were informed of the study's objectives, procedures, and potential benefits. They will sign a written informed consent form and were assured that participation was voluntary and that they could withdraw at any time without penalty. All collected data will be kept strictly confidential, stored in password-protected files, and will be disposed of in accordance with institutional guidelines after the prescribed retention period.

A. Intellectual Property Rights (IPR)

This study safeguarded intellectual property rights by ensuring that no original content required the development of new technologies. However, it contains unique materials, such as the survey instrument used to gather data, and was duly cited in the methodology section, which requires copyright protection to preserve the integrity of the work and prevent unauthorized distribution. All secondary sources, such as statistical information and literature on physical fitness standards, were attributed correctly. Trademark and patent protection were not applicable, as the study did not involve the creation of any unique brand, logo, or symbol that warranted trademark registration.

B. Informed Consent

Before their involvement, all participants will receive a thorough explanation of the study's goals, methodology, potential risks, and benefits. They will be given a written consent form in clear, easily understandable language to ensure they were fully informed of their right to withdraw from the study without facing penalties and consequences. Written consent will be

obtain from all respondents through a consent form, which assured them of the confidentiality of their responses.

C. Data Privacy and Confidentiality

The collection and protection of personal data from the respondents will be treated with strict confidentiality and obtained only with explicit consent. This study complied with the Philippines' Data Privacy Act of 2012 (Republic Act No. 10173). The collected data, including demographic information, names, and questionnaires, were treated strictly to prevent unauthorized access and protect participants' anonymity. Anonymized data were shared for academic purposes only in accordance with ethical guidelines.

D. Voluntary Participation

Participants in the study will be entirely voluntary. No human participants were coerced into participating in the study, and all participants were informed of their right to withdraw at any time without facing penalties or consequences. The study excluded respondents who were unable or unwilling to provide informed consent, such as minors or individuals with cognitive impairments. Additionally, no animals were used in any aspect of this study. The principles of voluntary participation were upheld to ensure ethical compliance.

E. Minimization of Harm

To ensure the safety and well-being of the participants, a thorough risk assessment will be conduct to ensure that their participation did not result in any psychological, emotional, or financial distress. Given the nature of the study, questions will be structured carefully to avoid triggering discomfort or stress. Participants were fully informed of their rights before participating in the study, including their right to withdraw at any time if they felt discomfort or distress. Support services were also available to assist the participants in distress if needed. Ethical

considerations for animal participants were not applicable, as no animals were involved in the study.

F. Beneficence and Contribution to Knowledge

This study aimed to contribute valuable insights into police officers' perceptions of physical fitness following the implementation of standards. It examines how police officers perceived those standards, providing valuable insights to improve job performance. In addition, the study identified several key outcomes of the physical fitness standards, including improved operational readiness, which enhances public protection and operational excellence. It will also results in a healthier workforce through programs like Pulisteniks, which promote fitness and weight management, and a positive public image for the organization and community. To ensure transparency and knowledge sharing, the research findings were communicated through a summarized report to police personnel and the officer-in-charge/chief of police.

G. Justice and Fair Participant Selection

The study adhered to the principles of justice and fairness in participant selection, ensuring participants were selected based on fair and transparent inclusion and exclusion criteria. Human participants from diverse backgrounds were included to avoid bias and discrimination and ensure equal participation opportunities. No group was disproportionately burdened or excluded from participation. Additionally, the study did not involve the use of animals at any stage of the research process.

H. Data Integrity and Accuracy

Standardized data collection and analysis methods will be employ to ensure the accuracy and reliability of results. The research actively minimized biases using consistent procedures and fair sampling techniques. Moreover, the study acknowledges its limitations, including possible

biases and constraints such as sample size, to uphold transparency and maintain the overall integrity of the research process.

I. Transparency and Honesty in Reporting

The study adheres to the principle of transparency in reporting by ensuring that all findings are reported truthfully. Every effort will be made to maintain accuracy and avoid manipulation or misinterpretation. All third-party materials used in the study were cited correctly to maintain research integrity and provide due credit to their sources.

J. Use of Patented or Copyrighted Materials

The researcher will not utilize any patented technologies. However, the study will use copyrighted academic literature, legal documents, and secondary data related to the study. Appropriate permissions and acknowledgments will be secured to ensure compliance with intellectual property laws and uphold academic integrity.

K. Ethical Considerations for Animal and Human Trials

This study adhered to ethical standards for human research and will not involve animals at any stage. All participants will be informed of the potential risks and benefits before taking part in the research. Ethical clearance for animal use will not be required because no animals will be involved in the study. This adherence to ethical guidelines ensured that the rights and welfare of all participants will be protected throughout the research process.

L. Responsible Use of Artificial Intelligence and Related Technologies

The study used artificial intelligence tools responsibly and ethically to help the research process. The researchers safely use AI tools. ChatGPT help the researcher organize their thoughts and put their ideas in order during the early stages. Grammarly will be use to ensure the writings clear and grammatically correct. The researcher review all AI-generated content to ensure

accurate interpretation and understanding. Furthermore, participants will be inform about using these technologies to uphold transparency and reinforce ethical standards throughout the study.

M. Ethical Approval

The appropriate ethics committee of Saint Michael College of Caraga will review and approve this research to ensure the compliance with ethical standards, including protection of participants, data privacy, and intellectual property rights.

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